CHAPTER 26

H O U S I N G A N D C O N S T R U C T I O N I N T H E P O S T W A R D E C A D E

CONSTRUCTION REQUIREMENTS

The requirements for construction in the postwar decade have two distinct components: There are first the requirements for supplying the current backlog of construction, clearing the slums, providing for the natural increase of the resident population, and making up additional obsolescense as it occurs. This is no mean job in itself. Secondly, there are the requirements for supplying the buildings for an influx of new immigrants.

Housing Construction

Construction requirements for housing alone, without immigration and with varying degrees of immigration, are set forth in Table 31. These housing requirements estimates are based on the standard of 2 persons per room, which means that 4 persons would be living in each two-room apartment. Given existing differences in income and corresponding differences in housing accommodation, an average of two persons per room would mean that many families would be living three and four persons in a single room. In the urban slums, and in very poor or rapidly expanding rural areas, even five and six persons to a room are to be expected. It is therefore not a generous level of accomodation, by Western standards, that we are stipulating. Yet it is higher than Palestine has today and may be quite beyond the reach of the Arab population even after a decade of progress.

The first item in Table 31, elimination of backlog and slum clearance, is based on the most authoritative estimate available on the housing backlog. It was prepared by a central committee of Arabs and Jews under the chairmanship of the Controller of Heavy Industries. This estimate indicates that at the end of 1944 the housing backlog amounted to 93,130 rooms, and 44,000 rooms were needed for slum clearance, making a total of almost 140,000 rooms